7.7.1 Biodiversity conservation in India

India is one of the 17 mega bio-diverse countries of the world (according to Conservation International). With only 2.4% of the world's land area, 16.7% of the world's human population and 18% of livestock, it contributes about 8% of the known global biodiversity. India has a number of globally important endangered species like Asiatic lion, Asian elephant, one-horned rhinoceros, Gangetic river dolphin, snow leopard, Kashmir stag, dugong, gharial, great Indian bustard, lion tailed macaque etc. The following steps have thus been taken to protect and manage the wildlife of the country.

1. The Government of India enacted the **Wild Life (Protection) Act 1972** with the objective of effectively protecting the wild life of this country and to control poaching, smuggling and illegal trade in wildlife and its derivatives.
2. The **National Board for Wildlife (NBWL)** chaired by the Prime Minister of India, provides for policy framework for wildlife conservation in the country.
3. The **National Wildlife Action Plan (2002–2016)** was adopted in 2002, emphasizing the people's participation and their support for wildlife conservation.
4. The Indian Constitution lays the subject of forests and wildlife in the **Concurrent** list thus laying the responsibility of wildlife conservation on both the Centre and the State.

Table 7.1 Specialised projects in India

Sl.No	Name of the Project	Year
1	Project Tiger	1973
2	Operation Crocodile	1975
3	Project Rhinoceros	1987
4	Project Snow Leopard	–
5	Project Elephant	1988
6	Project Sea Turtle	1999

5. **Specialised projects:** To save the endangered species of animals, specialised projects are being implemented with international cooperation (WWF, UNDP, UNEP, IUCN) as well as on a stand-alone basis like the following: (Table 7.1)

More recently, the Black Buck (chinkara) the Great Indian Bustard and the snow leopard have been given full or partial legal protection against hunting and trade throughout India.

6. The Protected Areas of India

Protected areas are those in which human occupation is small and exploitation of resources is limited. These are defined according to the categorization (Table 7.2.).

There are 4 categories of the Protected Areas in India.

- National Parks,
- Wildlife Sanctuaries,
- Conservation Reserves, and
- Community Reserves.

National Park

- National parks in India are IUCN category II protected areas.

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